

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Why People Hurt People

In the second week of February, Darius came in with a question.

Darius had been quieter than usual all week. He had been thinking. Thinking, for Darius, was usually a wearing-red activity, and this week he had been wearing red shirts and red pants and even, on Wednesday, red socks. By Friday morning he looked like a small thoughtful tomato.

When Ms. Calloway came in for the lesson, Darius raised his hand before she had even said hi.

"Yes, Darius?"

"Ms. Calloway. I have a question. Can I ask it before you start?"

"Of course you can. What is your question?"

"Why are some people just mean?"

The class was quiet.

Ms. Calloway thought about this for a moment.

"Darius, can I ask you why you are asking?"

Darius hesitated.

"My uncle came over for dinner last weekend. He always says things to my dad that — that make my dad sad. About my dad's job. About my dad's hair. Just — small mean things. All night. My dad does not say anything back. My dad just gets quiet."

"And after he left, I asked my dad — *why does Uncle James always say things like that?* And my dad said *it's complicated, buddy. Some people are just like that.* And I asked him *is he mean?* And my dad said *I don't know if mean is the right word.*"

"So I have been thinking. Is Uncle James mean? And — are some people just mean? Like, are they just born that way? Is that a thing?"

The class was very still.

Ms. Calloway sat down on the small stool she sometimes used during lessons. She did not stand at the front. She sat in front of the carpet, the way she had in first grade.

"Darius. What a thoughtful question. Today's lesson is exactly about this. I am going to answer your question and then I am going to teach the lesson, and they are going to be the same thing. Is that okay?"

"Yes."

"Okay. Here is what I think — and many adults think this, but not all of them. Almost nobody is just mean. When somebody is being mean, it is almost always because they are carrying something heavy. They are in pain. They are tired. They have been hurt. They have been carrying a thing they have not figured out how to put down, and the carrying makes them push other people."

"They are not pushing because they hate the other person. They are pushing because their own backpack is so heavy that they are about to fall over. And when people are about to fall over, sometimes they push other people. Not on purpose. Just to keep their balance."

"Your Uncle James is probably carrying something. Maybe a lot of somethings. He is probably tired. He is probably scared of something. He is probably — and this is interesting — he is probably jealous of something about your dad, even though

you might not be able to see it. People are mean to people they are jealous of. The meanness is information about the meaner, not about the person being mean'd to."

Darius was listening hard.

"Wait. So Uncle James is — Uncle James is being mean because of himself, not because of my dad?"

"Almost always, yes. The meanness is about the meaner. Not about the person on the receiving end. Your dad has not done anything wrong. Your dad is fine. Uncle James is the one with the heavy thing."

"What is his heavy thing?"

"I don't know, Darius. You might never know. Sometimes people do not tell us their heavy things. Sometimes they do not even know themselves. We just see the behavior. The behavior is the thing on the outside. The heavy thing is on the inside. We are seeing one but not the other."

Darius thought about this.

Then he said, "So when somebody is mean to me — at school — that's because they have a heavy thing? Not because I deserve it?"

"Almost always, Darius. There are very, very, very few times when somebody is mean to a kid because of the kid. Almost every time, the meanness is about the meaner."

"Huh," said Darius.

"And here is the important part," said Ms. Calloway. "Knowing that the meanness is about the meaner — does that excuse it? Does it make it okay?"

"No," said Darius.

"Right. It does not make it okay. The behavior is still the behavior. Your Uncle James should still try to do better. The kids at school who are mean should still try to do better. Understanding the why does not erase the impact. But

understanding the why means you do not have to carry their stuff on top of your own stuff. They are responsible for their own backpack. You do not have to wear it for them."

Darius nodded.

"That makes me feel — better. A little."

"How?"

"Because when somebody is mean to me, I sometimes think — *am I bad*? And now I am realizing that probably they are just sad about their own stuff."

"Yes, sweetheart. Exactly. That is the lesson."

She stood up. She walked to the board.

She wrote, in large green letters:

MOST MEANNESS IS ABOUT THE MEANER, NOT YOU.

She underlined it twice. She turned around.

"Friends. This sentence is for every single one of you. Memorize it. Carry it. When somebody is unkind to you — a sibling, a parent, a classmate, an adult you do not know — your first hypothesis should be *they are carrying something heavy*. Not *I am bad*. Not *I did something wrong*. *They are carrying something heavy*."

"Sometimes you are right. Sometimes you might be wrong — there are a few mean people who really are just mean, and we will talk about how to spot them in Chapter Twenty-Three. But your default should be the hypothesis. The default protects you. The default lets you walk through the world without taking on other people's pain as your own evidence that you are bad."

Priya, in the back, raised her hand.

"Ms. Calloway? What about when the meanness is from somebody who is supposed to be on your team? Like — your mom? Or your aunt? It feels different when it is from somebody who is supposed to love you."

Ms. Calloway was quiet for a long moment.

"Priya. That is a beautiful question. And the answer is — yes, it does feel different. It is also harder. Because the people who are supposed to love you have a bigger effect on you when they hurt you. Their words go in deeper."

"The same principle still applies, though. If your aunt called you *too sensitive* at Thanksgiving — and I am being general here, this could be anyone's aunt — it is still about her. Your aunt is probably uncomfortable with sensitivity. She probably learned, when she was a child, that sensitivity was dangerous and had to be hidden. Now, when she sees a sensitive niece, she is not seeing you. She is seeing the part of herself she had to hide. And the hiding is leaking out as a comment about you."

"It still hurts. It hurts maybe more than the school meanness. Because the love is real, and the hurt is real, and they are sitting in the same room together."

"What you do, with family who hurts you, is two things. One — you remember that it is about them. You do not take it as evidence about you. Two — you can, eventually, when you are old enough to have these conversations, tell them. *Aunt Beth, when you said I was too sensitive at Thanksgiving, that hurt. I want you to know.* You do not say it angrily. You say it as information. Some adults will hear it and apologize. Some adults will say *oh stop, you are being too sensitive again*, which is just proof of the original point. You cannot fix them. You can only tell them how it landed."

"Some adults you love, you will have to love from a small distance. That is part of growing up. We will talk about it more in Chapter Twenty-Three."

Priya nodded slowly.

"Friends. Let me leave you with one more thing for today."

She wrote on the board:

THEIR PAIN IS NOT YOUR EVIDENCE.

"Other people's pain — including the pain that comes out as meanness — is not evidence about you. It is evidence about them. Their pain is their data. Not yours. Do not take their data and pretend it is yours."

The bell rang.

The kids gathered their things. Darius went up to Ms. Calloway's desk.

"Ms. Calloway?"

"Yes, Darius?"

"I am going to tell my dad what you said. About Uncle James probably carrying something. I think my dad will like it."

"That is a beautiful thing to tell your dad, sweetheart. Go."

Darius went.

That night, at dinner, he told his dad what Ms. Calloway had said. His dad was quiet for a long time. Then his dad said, *buddy. I have been carrying — I have been carrying the thing your uncle says about my job. I have been carrying it for thirty years. And you just — you just took some of it off of me. By saying it out loud. Thank you.*

Darius hugged his dad. His dad, who is not a crying kind of dad, cried a little. Just a small amount. Then he wiped his face and said, *okay, buddy. Let's eat.*

They ate.

This is what Unit Three is going to do, all the way through. It is going to teach you to see other people's pain — not as evidence about you, but as evidence about them. It is going to teach you to forgive them, when you choose to. And it is going to teach you, importantly, that you do not have to keep them close just because you have forgiven them. That is Chapter Twenty.

We are going to get there.

For now: Darius told his dad. The dinner went better than usual. The dad was, that night, a few pounds lighter than he had been at breakfast. Ms. Calloway's chart on the wall said MOST MEANNESS IS ABOUT THE MEANER, NOT YOU.

The chart would stay up for the rest of the year.